WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

In a market dominated by global companies, Vineeta changed how beauty products are designed and sold to Indian consumers

Beauty, Made in India

An alumnus of IIT Madras and IIM Ahmedabad, Vineeta Singh, who was raised in Delhi, walked away from a Rs 1 crore campus placement in 2007. She was 23, and determined to build her own company. Her first two ventures—one in background verification services for recruiters and the other a monthly beauty subscription box—didn't take off. But failure perhaps taught her how to be third time lucky. SUGAR, which she started in 2015 with her husband, Kaushik Mukherjee, broke through the clutter with beauty products for Indian skin tones that could withstand Indian heat and humidity.

But it has been a rollercoaster ride. Her elder son and SUGAR were born just two months apart, and Singh recalls how tough it was to balance both roles, with Kaushik a strong source of support. Rejected by over 100 investors, Vineeta says it was particularly tough for a woman-led startup catering to women customers. The turnaround came in 2022, when global private equity firm L Catterton and actor Ranveer Singh invested in the company. "We proved that a homegrown brand could lead, not follow," she says. "We have been bold, unapologetic in our messaging that we cater to Indian skin and Indian attitude. My job is to keep pushing what 'Made in India' means in beauty—not the cheaper option but the aspirational one."

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"Be outrageously ambitious. There will be enough people underestimating you. Make sure you're never one of them"

What also helped was their early bet on social media. "That one call let a young brand reach the whole country without a war chest," says Vineeta. One of the sharks on the reality show *Shark Tank India*, her proudest milestone was when SUGAR successfully expanded offline. "We believed that Indian women want to shop for their makeup both on their phone and in their neighbourhood. So, during the COVID years, when most brands were giving up shelf space, we took the call to go offline, and that changed everything for us," she says. Today, SUGAR's 550 products across lip, eye and skin care besides other categories sell online as well as through 45,000 retail outlets—over 50 per cent of the company's business now comes from offline sales.



VINEETA SINGH, 43
Co-founder & CEO, SUGAR Cosmetics
Mumbai

HARDIK CHHABRA

Where does she find the resilience to keep moving forward or the perseverance to navigate chaos? They come from her passion for running, says Vineeta. A triathlete and ultra-marathoner, the experiences have taught her how to keep her eyes on the road and never lose sight of the finish line.

That is also what makes her an inspiration for the 2,000 ambitious, self-made women who work at SUGAR, comprising 70 per cent of the company's strength. The marathon continues, and Vineeta plans to leave behind a "bold, profitable, proudly Indian organisation that employs thousands of women". ■

— Sonal Khetarpal